

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 19 & 20

CHAPTER 19: EMILY: ANIMALS

Flashback. January 1977.

The winter of 1977 was the coldest on record. The snow piled up in drifts against the farmhouse, burying the fences, burying the road.

Emily Rose was home.

She had left the University. She had left the dorm. She had left the life she wanted.

She was back in her childhood bedroom, under the quilt her grandmother had stitched.

But she wasn't the same girl who had left in September.

That girl was full of light.

This girl was full of... static.

She sat by the window, watching the snow fall.

She felt heavy. The Gambrolic made her heavy. It made her thoughts slow, like wading through syrup.

But even through the drug-haze, she felt *them*.

The Legion.

They were quieter now. The medicine dampened their voices. Instead of screaming, they whispered. Instead of burning, they itched.

A constant, crawling sensation under her skin. Like ants.

"Emily?"

Her mother stood in the doorway. She was holding a tray. Tomato soup. Grilled cheese.

"You need to eat, honey."

"I'm not hungry, Mama."

"You have to eat. You're wasting away."

Maria put the tray on the desk. She looked at Emily. Her eyes were rimmed with red. She had been crying. Again.

"The cat had kittens," Maria said, trying to force a smile. "In the barn. Four of them."

Emily looked up. "Kittens?"

"Yes. Why don't you go see them? It might cheer you up."

Emily stood up. Her legs were weak.

She put on her coat. Her boots.

She walked out into the snow.

The air was sharp, biting. It cleared her head a little.

She walked to the barn.

The barn was warm. It smelled of hay and animals. The cows were chewing their cud, a rhythmic, comforting sound. *Chomp. Chomp.*

Emily walked to the stall in the back.

There was a box lined with old towels.

A calico cat—Mittens—was curled up inside.

And nestled against her belly were four tiny balls of fur. Blind. Mewing.

"Hey, Mittens," Emily whispered.

She reached out a hand.

She wanted to touch the softness. She wanted to feel something pure. Something that wasn't corrupted.

As her hand approached the box, Mittens' head snapped up.

The cat's eyes, usually green and lazy, went wide.

Black.

The pupils dilated until there was no color left.

Mittens hissed.

It wasn't a warning hiss. It was a scream. A high-pitched shriek of absolute terror.

She scrambled backward, trampling the kittens.

Mew! Mew!

The kittens cried out in pain.

Mittens didn't care. She was trying to get away. She clawed at the side of the box, her nails tearing the wood.

She looked at Emily as if Emily were a monster. As if Emily were made of fire.

"No," Emily whispered. "It's me. It's Emily."

She reached out again.

The cows behind her started to low. A deep, mournful sound that rose in pitch.

Moooooooo!

They began to kick the stalls. *Bang. Bang. Bang.*

The horses in the next aisle whinnied, rearing up, their hooves striking the wood.

The barn exploded into chaos.

Animals screaming. Stomping. Panicking.

Because of her.

Emily pulled her hand back.

"I'm sorry," she sobbed. "I'm sorry."

She backed away.

Mittens was arched in the corner of the box, spitting, her fur standing on end. She urinated on the kittens in her fear. The smell of ammonia cut through the hay.

Emily ran.

She ran out of the barn, into the snow.

She collapsed in the drift.

She looked at her hands.

They looked normal. Pale. Thin.

But to the animals...

To the animals, her hands were dripping with darkness.

To the animals, she wasn't a girl.

She was a vessel. A cage full of wolves.

We are here, the voice whispered in the wind. *And we are unclean.*

Emily lay in the snow. The cold seeped into her bones.

She wanted to stay there. She wanted to let the snow cover her. To freeze the wolves.

But she stood up.

She walked back to the house.

She didn't tell her mother about the kittens.

She didn't tell her about the horses.

She went to her room.

She locked the door.

She looked at the crucifix on the wall.

"Why?" she whispered.

The crucifix didn't answer.

But in the corner, the shadows lengthened.

And a spider crawled out of the crack in the floorboard.

It stopped. It looked at her.

It didn't run away.

It crawled toward her.

Because spiders don't fear the dark.

They live in it.

CHAPTER 20: ERIN VS OWEN

The sleet was coming down in sheets, coating the world in a layer of treacherous glass.

Erin Bruner stood under the awning of the courthouse, smoking a cigarette. She didn't smoke. She had quit five years ago. But today, after the lightbulb exploded, after Moore's testimony... she needed the nicotine.

She watched the smoke curl up into the grey air.

Her hand was shaking. Just a little.

The bruise on her wrist—the handprint from the elevator—was throbbing. It felt like a burn.

"You shouldn't smoke. It's bad for the skin."

Erin didn't turn around. She knew the voice. Deep. Baritone. Reasonable.

Owen Thomas.

He stepped under the awning. He was wearing a beige trench coat that looked expensive and warm. He held a black umbrella that was shedding water like a duck.

"I thought Methodists didn't judge," Erin said, taking a drag.

"We judge everything, Erin. We just do it quietly."

Owen stood next to her. He looked out at the street. Cars were sliding on the ice.

"That was quite a show in there," he said.

"It wasn't a show, Owen. The lightbulb really exploded."

"Old wiring. Moisture in the fixture. Physics."

"Is that what you're going to tell the jury?"

"I'm going to tell the jury that Father Moore is a charismatic man who knows how to manipulate a room. And that you are a brilliant attorney who knows how to stage a scene."

Erin flicked ash onto the pavement.

"I didn't stage it."

"Didn't you?" Owen looked at her. His eyes were kind. That was the worst part. He wasn't a monster. He was a decent man who thought he was saving the world from people like her.

"Erin, look at yourself. You're exhausted. You're jumpy. This case... it's getting to you."

"I'm fine."

"You're not fine. You're seeing things. I see it in your eyes. You're starting to believe him."

Erin looked away. "I believe in my client."

"You believe in winning. But what if winning means letting a killer walk free?"

Owen turned to face her. He reached into his pocket.

"I talked to the DA. We're willing to make a deal."

Erin froze. "What kind of deal?"

"Involuntary Manslaughter. We recommend a suspended sentence. Two years probation. No jail time."

Erin stared at him.

"No jail time?"

"He pleads guilty. He admits negligence. He keeps his collar. He goes back to his parish. And this... circus... stops."

It was a good deal.

It was an incredible deal.

Karl would jump at it. The Archdiocese would jump at it.

It was a win.

She would get the partnership. She would get the corner office.

And Moore would be free.

"Why?" Erin asked. "Why offer this now? You're winning."

"Am I?" Owen looked at the courthouse doors. "The jury is scared, Erin. You scared them. And scared people are unpredictable. I don't want to risk an acquittal. And I don't want to destroy a priest if I don't have to."

He stepped closer.

"Take the deal, Erin. End it. Go home. Sleep. Stop looking into the dark."

Erin looked at the cigarette in her hand. It was burning down to the filter.

"He won't take it," she said.

"Make him take it. You're his lawyer."

"He doesn't want to be free, Owen. He wants to be heard."

"He wants to be a martyr. Don't let him."

Owen put a hand on her shoulder. His grip was warm. Solid.

"You're a good lawyer, Erin. Don't become a casualty of his war."

Erin looked at his hand.

It felt... heavy.

For a second, she saw the handprint on her wrist. The purple bruise.

Owen's hand was in the exact same spot.

She pulled away.

"I'll take it to him," she said. "But the answer will be no."

Owen sighed. He looked disappointed.

"Then God help him," Owen said. "Because I won't."

He opened his umbrella. *Snap.*

He walked out into the sleet.

Erin watched him go.

The deal was a lifeline. A way out of the nightmare.

But as she watched Owen walk away, she realized something.

He was afraid too.

He had offered the deal because he felt it. The cold. The static.

He wanted it to end because he was scared that if it went on... he might start believing too.

Erin dropped the cigarette. She crushed it under her heel.

"No deal," she whispered to the rain.

And the thunder answered.

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